

Who Pays and Who Decides: A Signal

谁承担，谁决定：一个信号

Theme: 社会问题、经济与公共生活 · New: 44 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 44/6,127

English Story

The river had taught them to publish the weak numbers; the city would teach them who pays for them. The ninth arc opened with a **blow** to the city budget and a question that was not **relevant** to the election: who pays for the water treatment plant? A **presidential briefing**, a **congressional** hearing, and a **budgetary** review had all been scheduled for the same morning. “The favourite answer is a **slogan**,” the mayor said. “The **feasible** one is a fare.”

The signal was a **banknote** and a **coin** on the table. “**Enforcement** without a **receiver** is **theft**,” the treasurer said. “**Comply** or pay, but someone has to collect.” A **basketball** court, a **tennis** court, and a **volleyball** court had been promised in the same document, and the **basket** of revenue was empty.

The **briefing** was **authoritative** and the **grammar** was **flawless**. “We must **rid** the budget of the **habitual** exception,” she said. “A **privileged chimney** and an ordinary one should **undergo** the same inspection.” The **elephant** in the room was the **candidacy** of the deputy mayor, whose **moody indifference** to the numbers was well known.

A **bystander** at the hearing asked the only **grammatical** question of the day: who is the subject of this sentence? A **persistent leftist** on the council, a **prayer** group, and a **burial** society all asked the same thing. “A **sin** is not a line in a budget,” one of them said.

The proposal was to **facilitate** the collection of a small fee and to **discard** the rest. “If we **err**, we should **err** on the side of the poor,” the mayor said, with more **grace** than the room expected. A **coin**, a **banknote**, and a **basket** of receipts were passed around the table.

The next step was a public register of every exemption, published while the process was still open. It was the first signal that the trade-off would be visible, and the room went quiet for a while. Everyone between the two sides needed a while to agree, and almost nobody wanted to go into the water question again. The air in the room was thick; the land values, the process, and the stars of the evening news were all on the same page. Thus the need for a public register became obvious to us, and someone at the back began to write it down. Within the hour, the **favorite** proposal was to **purify** the water **fairly** and to share the cost.

中文翻译

这条河教会他们公开难看的数字；而这座城市教会他们，谁为这些数字付钱。第九段弧线以对城市预算的一记重击，以及一个与选举无关的问题开场：谁为水处理厂付钱？一场总统简报、一场国会听证和一次预算审查都被安排在了同一个上午。“最讨喜的答案是口号，”市长说，“可行的那个是票价。”

信号是桌上的一张钞票和一枚硬币。“没有收款人的执法就是盗窃，”司库说，“要么遵从，要么付钱，但总得有人来收。”同一份文件里承诺了篮球场、网球场和排球场，而收入的篮子却是空的。

简报是权威性的，语法无可挑剔。“我们必须把习惯性的例外从预算里清除掉，”她说，“有特权的烟囱和普通的烟囱应该经历同样的检查。”房间里那头大象是副市长参选这件事，而他对数字那种喜怒无常的漠不关心是众所周知的。

听证会上一名旁观者问出了当天唯一一个语法问题：这句话的主语是谁？议会里一位持久的左派、一个祈祷团体和一个殡葬协会都问了同样的事。“罪过不是预算里的一行，”其中一个人说。

提案是便利一笔小额费用的收缴，并把其余的都丢弃。“如果我们犯错，就该犯在穷人那一边，”市长说，其优雅超出屋里的预期。一枚硬币、一张钞票和一篮收据在桌上传递。

下一步是公开每一份豁免的登记册，并在流程仍然开放时就发布出来。这是第一个信号：取舍将被看见，而屋里静了一会儿。两边之间的每个人都需要一段时间才能一致，而几乎没有人愿意再回到那个水的问题上。屋里的空气是稠的；地价、流程，以及晚间新闻里的明星，全都在同一页上。因此，公开登记册的必要性在我们看来变得显而易见，而后排有人开始把它记下来。不到一小时，最受欢迎的建议就是公平地净化水并分摊费用。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
relevant 'relɪvənt POS: a	a. 有关联的, 有关系的, 适当的, 相应的; [法] 有关的, 相关的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. having a bearing on or connection with the subject at issue
fairly 'feəli POS: adv	adv. 美观地, 公平地, 相当地, 清楚地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. without favoring one party, in a fair evenhanded manner; r. in conformity with the rules or laws and withou...
blow bləʊ POS: n	n. 吹, 打击, 殴打, 花开; v. 吹, 风吹, 吹响, 开花 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a powerful stroke with the fist or a weapon; n. an impact (as from a collision); n. forceful exhalation thro...
favorite 'feɪvərɪt POS: n	n. 喜欢的事物, 幸运儿; a. 特别受喜爱的, 喜爱的, 宠爱的, 中意的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. something regarded with special favor or liking; s. appealing to the general public
presidential 'prezɪ'denʃəl POS: a	a. 总统制的, 总统的, 首长的, 统辖的; [法] 总统的, 议长的, 总经理的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. relating to a president or presidency; a. befitting a president
basketball 'bɑ:skɪtbɔ:l POS: n	n. 篮球 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a game played on a court by two opposing teams of 5 players; points are scored by throwing the ball throug...
prayer preɪ.'preɪə POS: n	n. 祈祷, 恳求, 祷辞, 祈祷者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of communicating with a deity (especially as a petition or in adoration or contrition or thanksgiv...
enforcement ɪn'fɔ:smənt POS: n	n. 执行, 强制; [法] 实施, 加强, 厉行 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of enforcing; ensuring observance of or obedience to
congressional kən'ɡresjənəl POS: a	a. 会议的, 议会的, 国会的; [法] 代表大会的, 大会的, 议会的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to congress
tennis 'tenɪs POS: n	n. 网球 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a game played with rackets by two or four players who hit a ball back and forth over a net that divides th...
rid rɪd POS: vt	vt. 免除, 以...清除, 使获自由, 使摆脱; [法] 免除, 清除, 摆脱 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. relieve from
coin kɔɪn POS: n	n. 硬币, 金钱, 货币; vt. 铸币, 创造, 杜撰 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a flat metal piece (usually a disc) used as money; v. make up
grammar 'ɡræmə POS: n	n. 语法学, 入门书; [计] 语法检查 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the branch of linguistics that deals with syntax and morphology (and sometimes also deals with semantics)
undergo ˌʌndə'ɡəʊ POS: vt	vt. 遭受, 经历, 忍受; [法] 经受, 经历, 忍受 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. pass through
basket 'bɑ:skɪt POS: n	n. 篮, 篮子; vt. 装入篮 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a container that is usually woven and has handles; n. the quantity contained in a basket; n. horizontal circ...
sin sɪn POS: n	n. 罪, 犯罪, 过失, 失礼; v. 犯 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. estrangement from god; n. an act that is regarded by theologians as a transgression of God's will; n. (Akkad...
receiver rɪ'si:və POS: n	n. 接收器; 接受者; 收信机; 收款员, 接待者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. set that receives radio or tv signals; n. the tennis player who receives the serve; n. a football player who...
comply kəm'plaɪ POS: vi	vi. 顺从, 依从; [法] 遵守, 承诺, 照做 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. act in accordance with someone's rules, commands, or wishes
theft θeft POS: n	n. 盗窃, 失窃, 盗窃罪, 赃物; [法] 盗窃行为, 偷窃, 失窃 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n the act of taking something from someone unlawfully
facilitate fə'sɪlɪteɪt POS: vt	vt. 使容易, 促进, 帮助; [法] 使容易, 使便利, 推进 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. make easier; v. increase the likelihood of (a response)
grace ɡreɪs POS: n	n. 优雅, 风度, 慈悲, 恩惠, 体面, 赦免, 恩典, 谢恩祷告; vt. 使优美 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (Christian theology) a state of sanctification by God; the state of one who is under such divine influence...
elephant 'elɪfənt POS: n	n. 象 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. five-toed pachyderm; n. the symbol of the Republican Party; introduced in cartoons by Thomas Nast in 1874

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
persistent pe'sistent POS: a	a. 固执的, 坚持的, 持续的, 作用持久的; [法] 坚持的, 固执的, 持续的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. never-ceasing; a. retained; not shed
burial 'berɪəl POS: n	n. 埋葬, 葬礼; [法] 埋葬, 葬礼 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the ritual placing of a corpse in a grave
discard dis'ka:d POS: vt	vt. 丢弃, 抛弃; vi. 垫牌; n. 垫牌, 抛弃 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. anything that is cast aside or discarded; n. (cards) the act of throwing out a useless card or of failing t...
privileged 'prɪvɪlɪdʒd POS: a	a. 有特权的, 有特别恩典的; [法] 特许的, 有特权的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. blessed with privileges; s. not subject to usual rules or penalties
chimney 'tʃɪmni POS: n	n. 烟囱, 灯罩; [电] 烟囱 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a vertical flue that provides a path through which smoke from a fire is carried away through the wall or r...
grammatical grə'mætɪkl POS: a	a. 语法的, 合乎语法的; [法] 语法上的, 符合语法规则的, 文法上的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or pertaining to grammar; a. conforming to the rules of grammar or usage accepted by native speakers
slogan 'sləʊɡən POS: n	n. 呐喊声, 标语, 口号 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a favorite saying of a sect or political group
feasible 'fi:zəbl POS: a	a. 能实行的, 可行的, 适宜的; [法] 可行的, 可执行的, 可完成的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. capable of being done with means at hand and circumstances as they are
briefing 'bri:fɪŋ POS: n	n. 简报; [法] 简报, 情况的简要介绍 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. detailed instructions, as for a military operation
authoritative ə:'θɒrɪtətɪv POS: a	a. 权威性的, 官方的, 命令式的; [法] 官方的, 当局的, 权威的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. having authority or ascendancy or influence; s. of recognized authority or excellence; s. sanctioned by esta...
indifference ɪn'dɪfərəns POS: n	n. 不重视, 无兴趣, 漠不关心; [法] 中立, 不偏袒, 不重视 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. unbiased impartial unconcern
volleyball 'vɒlibɔ:l POS: n	n. 排球 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a game in which two teams hit an inflated ball over a high net using their hands; n. an inflated ball used...
candidacy 'kændɪdəsi POS: n	n. 候选人的地位, 候选资格; [法] 候选人的身份, 资格 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n the campaign of a candidate to be elected
leftist 'leftɪst POS: n	n. 左翼的人, 左派; a. 左派的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. believing in or supporting tenets of the political left
budgetary 'bʌdʒɪtəri POS: a	a. 预算的; [法] 预算的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to a budget
habitual hə'ɪtʃʊəl POS: a	a. 习惯的, 惯常的, 平常的; [法] 习惯的, 以习惯为常业的, 惯常的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s commonly used or practiced; usual
flawless 'flo:lɪs POS: a	a. 无瑕疵的, 无缺点的; [化] 无裂纹的; 无裂缝的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. without a flaw
moody 'mu:di POS: a	a. 心情不稳的, 郁郁寡欢的, 喜怒无常的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. United States tennis player who dominated women's tennis in the 1920s and 1930s (1905-1998); n. United Stat...
purify 'pjʊərɪfaɪ POS: vi	vi. 变纯净; vt. 使纯净, 净化, 提纯, 精炼 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. remove impurities from, increase the concentration of, and separate through the process of distillation; v. ...
bystander 'baɪstændə(r) POS: n	n. 旁观者, 目击者; [法] 候补陪审员, 旁观者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a nonparticipant spectator
err ə: POS: vi	vi. 犯错, 做错, 犯罪; [法] 弄错, 犯错误, 陈述 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. to make a mistake or be incorrect
banknote 'bæŋkneut POS: n	n. 钞票 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a piece of paper money (especially one issued by a central bank)